was little more than an unnamed and unknown road. There were no amenities within the colony, except for a red postbox that looked quite forlorn and incongruous. I had already exhausted my annual leave for the year, studying for the DSSC exam. Fortunately for me, there was a requirement to attach an officer with MI-17, the section of the Military Intelligence directorate that deals with aerial imageries and their interpretation. Since I had qualified on the Imagery Interpretation Course, I was nominated for the same and got to spend six weeks in Delhi, helping Veena during the final days of her confinement.

Back at Gwalior, I would ring up once or twice a week, late at night, from the telephone exchange, as half rates came into play after 10 p.m. Diwali was just around the corner and I hoped to be in Delhi then as the due date was also around that time. When I rang up on 16 October, I was in for a surprise. My father-in-law picked up the phone and told me that Amala, our daughter, had been born at 6 p.m. that day. I went back to the unit, roused Col Dhariwal from his bed and requested for leave, which was, of course, immediately sanctioned. I was told to hand over my duties to Vivek, so I went to his house and roused him out of bed too. We both went to the office and did a proper handing/taking over of all the secret and confidential documents; there were no shortcuts or doing things 'in good faith', which could lead to security lapses later. A quick halt at home to freshen up and pack a few things and then it was off to the railway station to catch whatever train came along first, travelling in an unreserved compartment. I reached Delhi and went straight to the hospital, the same New Delhi Nursing Home where Isha had been born. On reaching the room, I first went to Isha, who was three and a half years old by then, gave her a big hug and then went and hugged Veena and Amala. Amala is one of the names for

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